FIVE

The Sensible Voice

DANNY READ BOTH posts standing up, in my kitchen, in his delivery jacket, with his phone buzzing in his pocket every forty seconds to tell him he was late.

He reads the way he used to read management proposals at union meetings: once fast, to get the shape of it, and once slowly, looking for the clause that would hurt someone. I watched him do it. He has a face that doesn't hide much. I saw it go from amused, to interested, to the particular stillness he gets when he's found the clause.

Then he put my laptop down on the counter, very carefully, as though it might go off.

"It's a tax dodge, Nell," he said.

"You haven't even—"

"I've read it twice. I've read *you* twice. It's a tax dodge." He took his phone out, silenced it without looking, and put it back. "Rich charity wants some kit moved off its books. Doesn't want it on the accounts, doesn't want the auditors asking what a charity's doing with a teletype in a country house. So it pays a haulier cash, the haulier keeps it off the board, and some clerk with a rubber

stamp gets to feel clever. Cash, no weight, no charge, funny stamp. That's not a mystery. That's a Tuesday."

"Then what's *D. 3062*?"

"Somebody's filing system. Every clerk I ever knew had a private filing system. My old branch secretary dated everything by how many days till she retired." He shrugged. "People are strange about numbers. You're strange about numbers. No offence."

"None taken."

"Some taken."

"Some taken," I agreed.

He was nearly right. That's the thing about Danny. He's nearly always nearly right, and the gap between nearly and actually is so small that most people never notice it's there. I'd known him since I was nine. He used to come round on Sunday afternoons to argue with my father about cricket and pensions, in that order, at volume, and leave with half a cake. Years later, when I'd joined Coyle's myself, he came into head office to fight the first round of cuts and lost, politely and completely, and afterwards bought me a drink because I was the only person on the other side of the table who had looked embarrassed. When Dad died, Danny decided, without consulting me, that I was now his responsibility. He has never once mentioned it, and he has never once missed a week.

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HE'D DONE TWENTY years as a union rep, until there was no union left to represent. Not because anyone abolished it. It just thinned. Fewer members every year, then fewer meetings, then one year the branch secretary with the private filing system retired and nobody stood for the post, and that was that. Nothing ended. It stopped happening.

Now he delivered parcels for an app that rated him out of five. Strangers he'd never met gave him stars on their doorsteps. He'd been at four point nine for two years and said it was the most stressful number of his life.

"So I'm wasting my time," I said.

"I didn't say that." He picked up the laptop again and scrolled to the comments. "I said it's a tax dodge. People do strange things to hide money, and sometimes those strange things are interesting. You're good at this. You were always good at this. It's better than you sitting here reading that letter again." He nodded at the shelf, where my redundancy letter was propped against my father's dictionary. He hadn't needed to look for it. "How many times this week?"

"Not many."

"Liar." He typed something into the comment box, quickly, the way he does everything. I didn't see what until it was posted.

It's a tax dodge, Nell. Ring me when you've eaten something.

"Danny."

"What?"

"You've just told four hundred people my name."

He looked at the screen. He looked at me. He had the grace to look ashamed for nearly two seconds. "Well," he said. "Now they can stop calling you Vesper. Sounds like a scooter."

* * *

ON SATURDAY HE took me to the Mission Hall.

I'd lived at the end of the same road for six years and never been inside. It's the kind of building you stop seeing: a long, low brick hall from the nineteen-twenties with a cross on the gable and a noticeboard out front that's mostly lost cats. On Saturday mornings it was a food bank. It was also, as far as I could tell, the only room in the neighbourhood where everyone ended up eventually: old men who'd lived on the estate since it was built, young mothers who'd arrived last year and didn't speak much English yet, students, a man in a good coat who'd lost his job and was trying very hard to look as though he was only there to volunteer. None of them looked especially pleased to be in the same room. All of them were.

There was tea. The tea was bad. There was a radiator under the window that banged every few minutes, loud as a dropped tray, as if something inside it was trying to get out. Nobody but me jumped.

Pastor Ama was at the tea urn. She was smaller than I'd expected and older, with reading glasses on a cord and the calm of someone who has spent decades in rooms where people are about to shout. Danny introduced me as *the one I told you about*, which I didn't love, and Ama put a mug in my hand and said, "Tell me."

So I told her. All of it: the box, the stamp, the logs, the date, the driver's note, the café. I'd never told it out loud from beginning to end, and it sounded madder than it did on the page and also, somehow, more real. And she did the thing almost nobody can do. She listened to the whole of it without interrupting once. She didn't nod to hurry me along. She didn't make the small noises people make to show they're about to speak. She just listened, until I'd finished and the radiator banged and I realised I'd been talking for twenty minutes.

"Well," she said. "That's a lot to carry on your own."

That was all. She didn't say whether she believed me. She didn't tell me what it meant. She just took the measure of the weight and said it out loud, and I had to look at the urn for a moment so she wouldn't see my face.

While I was looking at it, something happened at the front of the queue.

It was over so fast I almost missed it. An old man who'd been on the estate since before I was born said something to a young woman ahead of him with a pushchair, about who had been waiting longer, and she said something back, and in the space of four sentences both of them were standing very straight and talking too loudly. Nobody had touched anybody. Nobody had said anything unforgivable. But the whole hall had gone still in the way a room goes still before a glass breaks, and I watched three or four other people in the queue shift their weight towards one side or the other

without seeming to know they'd done it.

Ama didn't hurry. She put down the teapot, walked to the front, and stood between them, not quite facing either, and said, at a perfectly ordinary volume: "The radiator's going to go again in a minute. When it does, I'd like everyone to pretend they didn't jump."

The radiator banged. Nobody pretended. Somebody laughed, and then the old man laughed, unwillingly, and the young woman rolled her eyes and laughed too, and the room let its breath out. Ama made them both a tea, in the same pot, and handed them over without a word.

"That," said Danny, at my elbow, "happens about twice a morning now. Didn't used to."

"What's changed?"

He shrugged. "Rents. The scheme. Everyone's frightened and nobody knows who of." He drank his bad tea. "So they pick whoever's nearest."

* * *

THE LAD STACKING tins at the back was Jack.

He was nineteen, tall in the unfinished way of nineteen-year-olds, with a hoodie and a phone he checked between every tin. Danny called him over, and he came the way young men come when an older man they respect calls them: slowly, so it doesn't look like obedience.

"Jack," Danny said. "This is Nell. From Coyle's."

He looked at me properly then. "Head office," he said. "You did the training day. For the apprentices. Two years ago."

I had. I'd forgotten. Twelve of them in a meeting room, learning what a manifest was, and one tall boy at the back asking good questions and pretending not to care about the answers.

"I was at the depot," he said. "Loading, then planning. They were going to put me on routing." He said *routing* the way you'd say the name of someone who'd hit you. "Then the system went in,

and they didn't need anyone on routing. Kept me on loading for six months, then let the apprenticeship lapse. Letter said *restructuring*."

"Mine said *transition*," I said.

He almost smiled. "Same machine."

"Same machine."

We stood there for a moment, two people pushed off the same ladder by the same quiet hand, holding tins of chickpeas.

His mum's flat was on the Wharf Road estate. The council had sent round a letter about a regeneration scheme: new homes, better homes, a partnership with a private developer. There was a list of blocks for demolition in phase one, and his mum's was on it. Nobody knew where they'd be moved to, or when, or whether they'd be able to afford to come back.

"*Consultation*," Jack said, and put the word in quotation marks with his voice. "They're *consulting* us. Means they've decided."

He went by Jordan online, he told me, when I asked about the name on his phone screen. Jordan Pryce. It was a joke from when he was sixteen and it had stuck. Everyone round here called him Jordan.

"Except me," said Danny.

"Except Danny," said Jack. "When he's cross with me."

"Which is always."

"Which is always."

* * *

THAT NIGHT THE comments changed.

There had been odd ones before: the fertiliser man, the stranger who wanted me sectioned. But these were different. They came from an account with no picture, called **@longweather_, and they were long. Paragraphs. Confident, fluent, urgent. They explained what my manifest* really* meant, and every one of them ended in the same place: with a group of ordinary people, people you might live next door to, who were apparently to blame for everything. It

didn’t matter what the comment started with: the teletype, the stamp, the Harlow-Vane Institute. It always ended with neighbours. It always pointed down the street.

I’m not going to repeat what it said. I deleted it. Then I deleted the next one, and the one after that. They kept coming, and I kept deleting them, and somewhere around the fifth I realised my hands were cold.

Two things bothered me more than what it said.

The first was the name. *Long weather.* I checked. The account was older than my blog. It had existed since 2022. Somebody had chosen those words, with an underscore at the end, years before I’d found them stamped in purple on a sheet of paper in a box.

The second was smaller, and worse. In one comment, buried in the middle of a long paragraph, the account mentioned the archive. It mentioned that I’d *been back to the shelves on Tuesday*. And I had been. I’d gone back on Tuesday afternoon, to look for more 1971 logs. I hadn’t written about it. I hadn’t told anyone. Not even Danny.

I sat at the kitchen table for a long time after that, with the laptop closed, listening to the building make its night noises. I told myself it was a guess. Lots of people go back to things on Tuesdays.

I’m a reconciler. I know what a guess looks like. That wasn’t one.

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DANNY CAME ROUND the next evening with chips, because he’d decided I wasn’t eating, and he was right. I showed him the comments I’d kept: screenshots, not the words, because I didn’t want the words on my screen any more than I had to. He read them in silence. When he got to the one about Tuesday, he read it twice, and his face did the thing.

“Delete them,” he said.

“I have.”

"Keep deleting them." He put his chips down. "And listen. Whatever this is, if it's anything, if it's not a tax dodge, which it is…" He waited for me to smile. I didn't. "Whatever this is, it'll be some bloke in a suit. It always is. Twenty years I sat across tables from them. It's always some bloke in a suit, and he's always very polite, and he never, ever pays the price for anything." He pointed at my laptop. "Don't let anyone tell you it's the people down your street."

He said it to me, but he was looking past me as he said it, at the window. I turned.

Across the road, outside the block opposite, a small white van was idling with its lights on. A letting agent's van: the kind that comes round to check meters and photograph damp. It had a logo on the side, a simple shape, a bird in flight, and something about it snagged in me like a thread on a nail. I'd seen it somewhere. I couldn't think where.

The van sat there with its engine running for as long as Danny was at my window. When he left, it left.

I told myself that was a coincidence too.